Lesson 05: Parallelism

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 2.4: Parallelism; and from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.11: Parallel Structure.

In this lesson

Parallelism means giving related ideas the same grammatical form. Faulty parallelism makes a sentence sound clunky; good parallelism creates rhythm, makes complex ideas easier to follow and shows how ideas are connected. In this lesson you correct faulty parallelism in lists, comparisons and paired conjunctions, and you study how published researchers and famous speakers use parallel structure.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Recognize parallel and faulty parallel structure in words, phrases and clauses.
- Revise lists, pairs and comparisons with *than* and *as* so that every item has the same form.
- Use correlative conjunctions (both … and, either … or, neither … nor, not only … but also) correctly.
- Use parallel structure to make an academic paragraph clearer and more cohesive.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
parallelism (parallel structure)	the use of similar structure in related words, phrases or clauses	Driving a car requires coordination, patience, and good eyesight.
faulty parallelism	a lack of parallel structure	Ali prefers jeans to wearing a suit.
clunky	awkward and heavy to read	… the construction is clunky and confusing.
series	a list of three or more items	reduce its workforce, cut its benefits, or lower workers' wages
correlative conjunction	a paired conjunction that connects two equal parts of a sentence	either … or, not only … but also, neither … nor, whether … or, rather … than, both … and
comparison words	words that compare two items: than, as … as	Swimming in the ocean is much tougher than swimming in a pool.
gerund / infinitive	an -ing form used as a noun / to + a verb	I hate making stereotypes about others and hearing others making stereotypes about me.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
cohesion	the connections that help a reader follow a text	Parallel structure increases cohesion by showing your reader how ideas are connected together.
persist	continue with something difficult	women who persist in science and engineering
self-efficacy	a psychology term: a person's belief in their ability to succeed	direct implications for women's self-efficacy, experiences, opportunities, and success

Rules and explanations

What parallelism does

- Equal ideas get equal grammar: nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, prepositional phrases with prepositional phrases. The repeated construction lets readers focus on the idea instead of decoding the sentence.
- Parallel structure is a cohesion tool: the quotations in the first "Try this!" box are easy to guess because the second half repeats the pattern of the first.
- To check, underline each element and compare the forms. Grammar checkers do not find faulty parallelism, so read your draft aloud.

1. Words, verbs, phrases and clauses

Level	Faulty	Correct
words (same part of speech)	Stereotypes are inevitable and problems.	Stereotypes are inevitable and problematic.
nouns in a series	Driving a car requires coordination, patience, and to have good eyesight.	Driving a car requires coordination, patience, and good eyesight.
verbs (same form)	Kelly had to iron, do the washing, and shopping before her parents arrived.	Kelly had to do the ironing, washing, and shopping before her parents arrived.
verbs after another verb (hate + -ing or to: choose one)	I hate to make stereotypes about others and hearing others making stereotypes about me.	I hate making stereotypes about others and hearing others making stereotypes about me.
clauses	There is a lot of discussion about what women experience when they are studying science and engineering and better supporting them.	There is a lot of discussion about what women experience while studying science and engineering and how universities can better support them.

- With a coordinating conjunction (for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so), use the same structure on each side: "When I walk the dog, I like listening to music and talking to friends on the phone" (not "to listen ... and talking").
- In a series, the last item is where errors usually appear: "reduce its workforce, cut its benefits, or lower workers' wages" (not *lowering*).

2. Comparisons with than and as

Compare like with like: an action with an action, a thing with a thing.

- Swimming in the ocean is much tougher than swimming in a pool. (not "than a pool")
- Going for a brisk walk is as beneficial to your health as going for a run. (Sometimes you must add words.)
- Ali prefers wearing jeans to wearing a suit.

3. Correlative conjunctions

- The words after each part of the pair must be parallel: "We can neither wait for something to happen nor take evasive action" (not "nor can we take").
- Rearranging the sentence can help: "It was both a long movie and poorly written" → "The movie was both long and poorly written."
- Complete the pair: *neither* needs *nor* ("It was neither helpful nor useful"), *either* needs *or*, and *not only* needs *but also*: "Not only was the class long, but it was also boring." When *not only* begins the sentence, the helping verb comes before the subject (an inversion, as in Lesson 02).

4. Small words and sequence words

- Articles (a, an, the) and prepositions in a list are used either once or with every item: "The science fields, the technology fields, and the engineering fields" or "The science fields, technology fields, and engineering fields"; "In elementary school, in high school, or in college" or "In elementary school, high school, or college".
- Sequence words match: first, second, third, or firstly, secondly, thirdly. "First, I will explain the problem. Second, I will offer a solution" (not "Secondly").

5. Parallelism in published writing

In the research paragraph by Kathleen N. Smith and Joy Gaston Gayles ("Notice this!"), long sentences stay easy to follow because related ideas share one form: *staying and leaving*; *less to do with … and more to do with …*. (The last exercise in 2.4, on Alex's essay, is a picture that is not in your printed material.)

> **In psychology papers:** APA style (7th edition) may label the items of a series inside a sentence (a), (b), and (c); it also requires the items to be parallel.
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> **Note for Arabic speakers**
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> - Traditional Arabic prose is rich in parallel clauses joined with "and", often repeating one idea in several forms for emphasis. English academic writing uses parallelism mainly inside a sentence, for different ideas of equal weight; repeating one idea in parallel form can sound like padding.

Practice

1. Coordinating conjunctions (lesson material, 2.4, first exercise). Revise each sentence to create parallel structure.

1. Mr. Koirla enjoys reading and to play his guitar on weekends.
2. The doctor told Mrs. Hall that she should either eat less or should exercise more.
3. Breaking out of the prison compound, the escapees moved carefully, quietly, and were quick on their feet.
4. I have read the book, but I have not watched the movie version.
5. Deal with a full inbox first thing in the morning, or by setting aside short periods of time in which to answer e-mail queries.

2. Than or as (2.4, second exercise). Revise each sentence to create parallel structure.

1. I would rather work at a second job to pay for a new car than a loan.
2. How you look in the workplace is just as important as your behavior.
3. The firefighter spoke more of his childhood than he talked about his job.
4. Indian cuisine is far tastier than the food of Great Britain.
5. Amber's opponent was as tall as Amber and he carried far more weight.

3. Correlative conjunctions (2.4, third exercise). Revise each sentence to create parallel structure.

1. The cyclist owns both a mountain bike and has a racing bike.
2. The movie not only contained lots of action, but also it offered an important lesson.
3. My current job is neither exciting nor is it meaningful.
4. Antonio would rather listen to his father than be taking advice from me.
5. We are neither interested in buying a vacuum cleaner nor do we want to utilize your carpet cleaning service.

4. Complete the quotations (2.11, first "Try this!"). Guess how each of the nine quotations ends. Use the parallel structure to help you.

5. Find the parallel structures (2.11, "Notice this!"). In the paragraph by Smith and Gayles, find at least eight examples of parallel words, phrases or clauses.

6. Improve the parallel structure (2.11, last "Try this!"). Rewrite the three sentences from a student's body paragraph about stereotypes.

Speak with your tutor

- (Based on the book's tip in 2.4 and group activity in 2.5) "I have read 'I Have a Dream' (see Watch online). Here are five parallel structures I found and their effects: [list]. What did I miss? Does King always use parallelism for the same effect?"
- "Check my answers to Practice 1 to 3: [paste]. If more than one correction is possible, show me the alternatives."

- "Give me ten sentences about memory or child development from an introductory psychology course, each with faulty parallelism. I will correct them."
- "Here is a paragraph from my essay: [paste]. Mark every list, comparison and paired conjunction, and tell me which are not parallel. Let me correct them."

Read aloud

Stress the contrasting words (in capitals); | shows a short pause.

1. We make a living by what we GET, | but we make a life by what we GIVE.
2. Success is getting what you WANT. | Happiness is wanting what you GET.
3. Ask not what your COUNTRY can do for YOU; | ask what YOU can do for your COUNTRY.
4. People will forget what you SAID, | people will forget what you DID, | but people will never forget how you made them FEEL.
5. Not everything that is faced can be CHANGED. | But nothing can be changed until it is FACED.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words, then revise it as the book suggests: fix faulty parallelism, and add parallel structure where it would make the relationship between ideas stronger. Choose one topic:

- why some students persist in a difficult subject while others leave it (compare the paragraph on women in engineering);
- what helps people remember what they study (memory, a topic in PSYC 110);
- the qualities of a good communicator (compare the paragraph in Lesson 04).

Include one series of three items, one comparison with *than* or *as*, one correlative pair, and one pair of parallel clauses.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every item in a list has the same form (nouns, -ing forms, infinitives or clauses).
- Words joined by *and*, *but* or *or* have the same structure on both sides.
- Comparisons with *than* and *as* compare like with like.
- Each correlative pair is complete (neither … nor, not only … but also) and followed by parallel words.
- Articles and prepositions in a list appear once or with every item.
- Sequence words match (first, second … or firstly, secondly …).

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- "I Have a Dream" by Martin Luther King Jr., text and audio (the book's link, mlkonline.net, no longer has them and sends readers here): https://www.americanrhetoric.com/speeches/mlkihaveadream.htm

- The full article by Smith and Gayles, source of the "Notice this!" paragraph (open access): https://www.mdpi.com/2076-0760/7/1/11/htm

Answer key

1.

1. Mr. Koirla enjoys reading and playing his guitar on weekends. (*Enjoy* is followed by a gerund, so both verbs take -ing.)
2. The doctor told Mrs. Hall that she should either eat less or exercise more.
3. Breaking out of the prison compound, the escapees moved carefully, quietly, and quickly.
4. No change is needed: the clauses are already parallel (I have read … I have not watched …). Also correct: I have read the book but have not watched the movie version.
5. Deal with a full inbox first thing in the morning, or set aside short periods of time in which to answer e-mail queries. (two parallel commands) Also: Deal with a full inbox by working through it first thing in the morning or by setting aside short periods of time …

2.

1. I would rather work at a second job to pay for a new car than take out a loan.
2. How you look in the workplace is just as important as how you behave. (Also: Your appearance in the workplace is just as important as your behavior.)
3. The firefighter spoke more of his childhood than of his job. (Also: … more about his childhood than about his job.)
4. Indian cuisine is far tastier than British cuisine. (Also: The food of India is far tastier than the food of Great Britain.)
5. Amber's opponent was as tall as Amber and carried far more weight than she did. (Delete *he*, so that the two verb phrases share one subject.) Also: Amber's opponent was as tall as Amber but far heavier.

3.

1. The cyclist owns both a mountain bike and a racing bike.
2. The movie not only contained lots of action but also offered an important lesson. (Also: Not only did the movie contain lots of action, but it also offered an important lesson.)
3. My current job is neither exciting nor meaningful.
4. Antonio would rather listen to his father than take advice from me.
5. We are interested neither in buying a vacuum cleaner nor in utilizing your carpet cleaning service. (Also: We want neither to buy a vacuum cleaner nor to utilize your carpet cleaning service.)

4. (book)

1. … until it is faced. (James Baldwin)
2. … practice compassion. (The Dalai Lama)
3. … infinite hope. (Martin Luther King, Jr.)
4. … wanting what you get. (Dale Carnegie)
5. … how you made them feel. (Maya Angelou)

6. ... by what we give. (Winston Churchill)
7. ... preventing crime before it happens. (Kamala Harris)
8. ... We are never beyond repair. (Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez)
9. ... ask what you can do for your country. (John F. Kennedy)

5. (book) math and science; avoid or leave; women who persist in science and engineering / women who decide to leave; staying and leaving; less to do with the women themselves / more to do with the academic and workplace environments; academic and workplace (environments); attend school and pursue careers; science, technology, engineering, and math; structural and cultural (barriers); self-efficacy, experiences, opportunities, and success. (The book's key lists "women who persist in science and engineering" twice under "Clauses"; this is a mistake, because the second clause of the pair is "women who decide to leave".)

6. (book) Possible answers:

1. Having stereotypes highlights people's differences and makes equality nearly impossible to achieve.
2. What she means is that a single story usually focuses on what other groups do not have and what is beneficial for the people telling the story, rather than focusing on what is true.
3. This makes us look at our differences and makes society less equal.

(In the Adichie quotation after sentence 1, the book leaves out a word: in her talk she says that the single story "robs people of dignity".)

My notes